Raves and Civil Rights

headnote: *PLUR 4L*.

What exactly is a rave? For some, notably younger people, its simply a giant party. In a club, a festival, or an old dirty warehouse. It's a night to let the stress loose, to dance, do a bump or two, or maybe take some cool aesthetic pictures. To others, namely those who were there when the term was first coined, it is a political sanctuary, a safe space free from judgment and oftentimes, prosecution. Raves are inherently political and were created as a space by and for marginalized groups across the world. A simple night out at the club, or a weekend long EDM festival is not a rave. At the beginning, raves were an affirmation of your existence otherwise shunned by society at large. They were illegal, cheap, and existed solely to play underground music and at times, organize politically. The first raves started in the 1980s in Detroit, Chicago, NYC, LA, and London, particularly during a time of racial tensions and ostracizing homosexuality. The rave and the term in general has been co-opted by corporate nightclub entities in order to appear more authentic, while charging $40 cocktails with a dress code. At the original raves, there were no dress codes. You came as you are. You came to be accepted in public, to be free. There is nothing wrong with a simple night out at the club or going to an EDM festival, but the term and the history behind it deserves the distinct recognition that birthed its origin. In the 1980s, gay people were heavily oppressed and outcast. With the rise of the HIV./AIDS epidemic, being gay became a stigma and made you a target for harassment and assault. They were social outcasts, at least those that were brave enough to come out of the closet publicly through their appearance. Because it was common for men to dress flamboyantly in this era, any perceived gayness could get you jumped just based on what you were wearing. It was not uncommon to be denied entry into a club or bar for being visibly gay – enter the rave. The ignorance of the population and propaganda of the media would have you think just being in the presence of gay people or even slightly brushing against them would cause you to get AIDS. This paranoia was a main driver of discrimination despite the fact that AIDS was only transferred via sexual acts. Raves started popping up in order to let gay people simply live their lives away from public scorn and ire. They were political spaces in the midst of a failing health system that simply tried to sweep this problem under the rug, tragically taking the lives of almost 90,000 people (for context that is 9/11 thirty times to give you a scope of the trauma experienced by the community). At a rave, you were free from being beaten and harassed, they were an affirmation of your existence, dignity, and pride. They let you organize with other gay people to spread health resources, safe sex education, and AIDS testing. Above all else, they were a means of temporary escape from the horrors of the outside world and provided you with a sense of community. Raves were and still are inherently political, not just any gathering is a rave. The word has been co-opted because it sounds cool and that's where culture was created. As is the cycle of all underground movements co-opted by the mainstream, it dilutes the substance and actual underlying ethics, morals, origins, and norms of the movement. Even still, many believe racism ended in the 60s which is as far from the truth as can be. Raves were also a space for black people, Hispanics, and all people of color to be free and be themselves away from the boot of the state and the heavy conservatism and reactionary politics of the 70s, 80s, and 90s. This was also a time of social decay as investment in the inner cities stopped and white flight took the tax money out of cities and into the suburbs, crime reached its apex in 1994. For regular people who were poor, raves offered them an escape from the trauma of gun violence and the crack epidemic that plagued cities. In London, race riots and police brutality were occurring well into the 80s as the backlash towards an influx of immigrants from former British colonies increased. Oftentimes, they were only welcome outside of their community at a rave. Raves are inherently

political – peace, love, unity, and respect has an actual meaning to it, its not some cutesy phrase to repeat on molly or coke and to make a bracelet with the acronym. It reaffirms that intersectional value that none of us are free until we are all free. They embody a communal spirit of sharing music and relishing in our mutual humanity no matter where we came from. These social factors led to the creation of a rave, the word is not an all purpose term for some gritty aesthetic with loud techno music, they served and continue to serve a humane purpose for the marginalized and oppressed. The genres of today that we see as popular and widely accepted were also shunned. Techno, DnB, House – they had to be played at the rave because they were not allowed in most clubs or radio stations. This was all brand new, their origins are on pirated radio stations hosted by individual people in the underground scene. Concurrently were breakthroughs in sound engineering and accessibility to equipment with the release of Roland drum machines and synthesizers, as well as the availability of vinyls and tapes. This allowed DJs from all walks of life to explore their creativity to sample and loop instruments. The music once shunned that now top the charts today was created by marginalized, poor, gay black people in the inner city. It was only after word spread of the popularity of raves that they became co-opted and monetized for profit, like everything else in society. They attempted to dilute the origins in order to sell it to white people in the suburbs and those that were not affected by the ills of the day. People saw the dollar signs and that is why raves became popular, not because of any perceived altruistic vision of what is right and what is wrong. It was the original recession pop as we have come to understand, people wanting upbeat electronic music in order to carry their spirits, inspire them, and to curate their own identity and humanity amid times of societal decay, crises, and oppression. There are billions of people that live in repressive, authoritarian countries that still rely on illegal raves in order to organize, to be free and autonomous from oppression.

Raves existed because black, queer, and poor people needed them. Raves began because the outside world wasn't safe. For anyone aware of this history, there's no doubt that raving has always had a protest element to it. *Reclaiming the word is about reaffirming cultural ownership, sometimes gatekeeping is necessary to stave off corporate commodification, erasure, and re-writing history. It goes way back to the earliest days of clandestine gatherings, where those on the fringes of society would get together to party free from judgment. Whether it was conscious or not, the act of creating safe spaces, getting together and forming communities away from mainstream society was a form of resistance. Raving is a way to resist oppression. Over generations, the state has always tried to quash social movements where people come together and unite. By raving, you resist this oppression and create spaces where you can gather, unite, exchange ideas and experiences and facilitate social cohesion. PLUR is the literal antithesis of war and violence. Around the world, governments continue to create division, attacking other nations and perpetuating ignorant fueled violence. When you embrace the original ethos of Peace, Love, Unity and Respect, you embody a way of being that counteracts the war machine. Raves have always been progressive. Inclusivity, freedom of expression, equality, these are all ideals that are about taking humanity forward and cultivating a more harmonious society. By dancing as one, you perpetuate the progressive ethos of rave culture. Through these values, raves can facilitate social change and evolution. Over the last few decades it's been clear that rave culture can act as a driver for positive social change. Whether that be through the transformative experiences people have while dancing together, or the impact on peoples' perspectives, they can be places of pivotal change [excerpt is from the happy tuesdays lowdown blog].* I want to expand on something I mentioned in the first article, why it is important to not call every party, outing, or festival a "rave." Language matters and the more you misuse a term, you dilute the actual meaning and history behind it. Raves are very specific events and I believe the name should be gatekept, less it begin to lose the actual meaning and history behind the name through distortion. Raves were created as a counterculture outside the club industry. They were mostly illegal, DIY gatherings against the establishment, often fueled by political resistance. When you call every party, warehouse event, or

festival a “rave,” you flatten and warp history. If a corporation, business owner, or sponsorship is involved in anyway whatsoever, it is not a rave. The word has become bastardized from its specific political origins. A curated night at a club, a warehouse party, a free party at an abandoned factory, a commercial EDM festival, a trance open-air fest — these are not interchangeable. Calling all of them raves erases the communities and cultural roots that make each of them distinct. When the mainstream uses the word for corporate festivals, the true underground loses visibility, and the culture loses its language. Marketing adopts the word to imply underground credibility and create FOMO for commercial events while the price of one ticket remains half a grand. Just like hippies, bikers, rastas, punks, grunge, and hip hop, raving has fallen victim to the perpetual cycle of mainstream (capitalism) co-opting counter-culture and the underground for profit, often diluting its original anti-establishment and revolutionary origins. When this happens, the underground fragments into new eras and the cycle continues. Raving and electronic dance music was re-framed into a commercial category, optimized for festivals, sponsorships, and mass legibility. When language loses precision, corporations gain it. They can sell you the posture of resistance without any of the risk, ethics, or community responsibility that made the word matter in the first place. The term stopped pointing to a culture and started pointing to a product. In the current age, multinational, billion dollar venture capital firms own the majority percentage of the clubbing scene – venues, recording artist labels, and ticketing systems. Another reason that names matter is because the clubbing and festival scene now is purely owned by these venture capitalist firms who rely on co-opting underground norms, lexicon, and iconography for marketing purposes. Through monopolization, these once grassroots festivals have been morphed into nothing more than a portfolio for Wall Street. Venues will shut down, assets will be liquidated and sold off, talent will be dropped from major agencies, and bookings will become sparse the more late stage capitalism continues to eat itself in the 2020s. In its place will be what was there in the beginning, the DIY, all welcoming, non financialized rave. The death of an industry becomes a rebirth of the underground. When the bubble bursts, when mega clubs shutter and festivals fold, indie promoters that organize in the rubble will be the ones left standing. It will be artist led spaces with low capacity, invite only, the people who do it for the love of the art before it was profitable. There is precedent for this as it happened in the 90s in the UK and globally in the 00s, only for the cycle to die and start again. At the end of the day, communion around loud repetitive beats in dark smoky places will never truly die off. The rave is the only thing to still keep this authentic spirit alive. The underground isn’t dead, its just waiting for us to stop looking for it in festivals and Spotify playlists. Raves are non-commercialized spaces, they are not defined by genre, they are inherently political, they are not engineered for online viral circulation, they are not content, and they are not organized around profit. They don’t survive like companies. They reappear, migrate, dissolve and reform. Rave culture was never designed to scale, but to adapt. It was designed to gather, to create temporary autonomy and protect weirdness, risk, and refusal inside a world that tries to monetize everything. Calling everything a rave doesn’t make it cooler. It makes the culture disposable. A real rave economy is closer to mutual aid than a nightlife business. People share resources, bring things, and contribute quietly with no expected financial reward. It’s not VIP or an opportunity to flex. It’s not bottle service or a brand sponsorship. There’s nothing wrong with dance parties, club nights, warehouse events, festivals, or shows. They’re just not raves.

I know that raving is becoming more expensive and to some a luxury, but know this, the underground scene will never die. It will be reborn. It will continue to shift and reinvent itself. Raving means freedom and as the horrors of our dark world become more evident, people will need raves now more than ever. And I know that Gen Z and people in general are becoming less social, but I do not believe this will be sustainable, we are fundamentally social creatures and we like to dance together, it is an agnostic ritual open to all. The underground can never fully become co-opted by big business and

finance bros, it will simply change mediums. I have gathered a list of underground sources from around the world's major cities on each continent where you can follow along weekly for raves and other musical events that they post. Raving to electronic music will never go out of style or become too expensive to be enjoyed by society. It used to be that, in order to find a rave, you had to be someone in the know. You had to go to a record store, find a number to call or page that would then reveal an address after a certain hour. Today with the internet, information has moved online yet the need for secrecy or discretion still remains. I detest that everything is shared via Instagram, but I understand that is where people are and where word spreads. The underground however still operates on that basis of, exclusivity. Take for instance Book Club Radio in Brooklyn, or AlwaysLunes in Miami. Book Club Radio is invite only, it is not hard to receive one and those who care enough to look will find it. AlwaysLunes, while not as exclusive, still operates on a principle of emphasizing only underground spaces through weekly drops. I have gathered a collection of similar organizations and websites that fit this underground spirit. After all, you don't want just anyone coming to your rave, there is a certain elitism present as normies want to indulge in voyeurism or feel as if they are watching a minstrel show. Take for instance my anecdotal experience of attending The Castle in Tampa, FL. The Castle is a goth club specifically catering to the alternative and underground scene since 1992 that is still open today. While they mostly retain that counterculture, fringe spirit, normies (frat bros) of Tampa have began to brigade the space in an effort to fill a novel experience in their otherwise empty and culturally destitute lives without actually engaging in the culture. They simply want to attend a "circus" up close and gawk at the attractive goth women whom they see as inferior but nevertheless fetishize. And this phenomenon is nothing new, it happened to the original rave spaces back in 1980s Chicago as well. In addition to this, algorithms are increasingly contributing to the commodification of rave spaces and the financialization of expression through culture and art. It prompts the contemporary question that I've seen online, why does everyone wanna be a DJ now? The answer is simply because you can no longer be apart of a culture or community without producing something of value anymore. In order to be apart of a monetized culture, you have to produce content for clicks, likes, attention or sponsorship money. You're no longer given the chance to just be apart of a culture because that is your environment, or for the love of the art itself. Culture itself has become commodified through this monopolization of art and music. The marginalized need to reclaim the use of raving and music to express our culture so that it doesn't die off with the rest of the physical world. It's a way of forming community in our increasingly isolated world. I mention these anecdotal experiences to give you a glimpse as to why these methods of communicating our spaces to the open world should be kept behind a thin, gatekeeping layer. They may not be hosted in illegal spots anymore, but the culture is sacred and must be kept authentic behind these walls. Finding raves separate from Instagram and Tiktok is vital, and more importantly, we honestly don't even need them. I believe these organizations and websites maintain that same purity, while still remaining open to all who wish to become part of the community. (also check out my weekly electronica posts [here])